

A ROOF FOR ALL

The Centre's programme of housing for the poor has brought security and dignity to millions in the villages

By AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

THE DRUDGERY

For rural populations residing in thatched huts and makeshift houses, the challenges of everyday living are overwhelming. Other than the ravages of extreme weather, living practices mostly keep their abode misaligned with health objectives: ill-ventilated rooms and kitchens are common, and toilets, of course, are absent. According to NFHS (National Family Health Survey) data from 2016, when PMAY-G was launched, only 56.3 per cent of the population then had the good fortune of living in a pucca house.

THE EASE OF LIVING

In 1985, the Indira Awas Yojana was launched to provide housing for the poor, but glaring gaps persisted even after 30 years. Recognising the need for transformative action, the government launched the Prime Minister Awas Yojana-Gramin, or PMAY-G, in 2016.

The mission is simple—provide pucca houses equipped with basic amenities to all eligible homeless and other families living in kutcha or dilapidated houses. The original target was to build 29.5 million houses by March 2024. In August last year, the Union cabinet approved the construction of an additional 20 million free houses under the scheme. The revised target, therefore, now stands at 49.5

PM AWAS YOJANA-GRAMIN
Launched in 2016

Achievement: Out of the 33.2 million houses sanctioned under the PMAY-Gramin initiative, 26.8 million have been completed as of January 2025

HOW IT TRANSFORMED OUR LIVES

"Awas Yojana helped us when we needed it most"

Life had always been a struggle for Premchand Mahto, but he managed to keep his head above water. A daily wage labourer with a modest plot of farmland, he had married off two of his daughters. On a good month, when work was steady, he earned around Rs 10,000. Then, in 2023, fate dealt a cruel hand. A freak accident crushed his right leg, leaving him hospitalised for months.

Yet, even in those bleak times, there was a glimmer of hope. Mahto's wife Jitana Devi had become a PMAY-G beneficiary and before the accident, their modest thatched dwelling had been transformed into a pucca house. When Mahto returned home from the hospital, he found himself welcomed by the comfort of a proper roof, a toilet and even a separate room—a marked improvement that